

This recording is going to be about a recent little holiday break that I took with my wife Alison. Alison Chetham. I'm Andy Chetham. And we decided to take a three-night trip to London to see some art galleries, museums, see some shows, generally experience three days in London. We actually set off on Saturday the 29th of August in the morning. And we walked down with our cases trailing behind us on the wheely wheely wheely cases. Although Alison actually had a backpack, I was had the wheely case. And we got a train from Guiseley into Leeds. I remember when we got to Leeds railway station, we arrived just exactly at the right time. Well, when I say the right time, we had enough time to just go and get a cup of coffee. I think we got a sort of a croissant or something, then we went back onto the main station, stepped onto our LNER train from Leeds to King London King's Cross. We settled in and the train set off. And it was very comfortable. Um, Alison read a book for most of the way. I spent almost the entire time trying to write an email for work that I had to send at some point, even though I failed to uh finish it, even though even though I had over two hours, but I didn't finish it. But we arrived in London King's Cross. It was warm. The weather was reasonably pleasant. The forecast had been rain actually. We were expecting it to be quite rainy, so we'd brought our rain jackets. But when we got there, there was no sign of rain. It was a reasonably warm day, and uh, very pleasant. The hotel that we'd booked was the Crowne Plaza in King's Cross. Now, it was a little bit of an uh, well, it was a perfectly good hotel, but it did turn out to be a 15-minute walk from London King's Cross. So, there was like, you know, through the busy junctions around King's Cross station, up the road, then there was a left, and then a long bit of a walk, then a right, and then another bit of a walk. So, it was probably about a mile. But anyway, we got to we got to the hotel. We got to the hotel about half past twelve, very early. But we were fortunate in that they said we could go straight into our up to our room. So, we went up to our room, and we um, settled in and um, got ourselves ready to go out. Now, we decided we wanted to go and see the British Library. And I decided I wanted to see the British Library sometime ago when I learned that the venerable Bede's, I think it's called the Ecclesiastic History of England, is in the in the British Library. And so is the, or so are the um, Lindisfarne Gospels. And I thought it would be quite amazing to see those books, even if behind a glass cabinet in a museum. And the British Library is right next to King's Cross. So we walked all the way back to King's Cross station, a little bit past the station, a little bit further up Houston Road, turn right, and there's the British Library and we went in. First thing we did, we went to the to the restaurant. We had a very pleasant salad, and a few other bits and a drink. Um, and then we we went into the what's called the treasure room. Uh, I was very happy to find the British Library is free to enter. So, you know, that was good. Anyway, we went into the treasure room, and it was incredible. They had the Magna Carta in there, that was their prize kind of exhibit. But there was plenty of other quite extraordinary ancient books, historic books. There was a lot of um, of spiritual based books, whether that's Christianity with very early Bible passages and um, both New and Old Testament. There was a lot of Buddhist um, work as well, and Hindu works. But there was also sort of interesting things like um, like original copies of The Beatles lyrics that had been written by Paul McCartney and John Lennon. There were some Monty Python original uh, scripts, written, you know, it was it was a really nice visit. I was but however, what I'd come to see, which was the Lindisfarne Gospels and the Ecclesiastic History of England, was not on display. These are described as rare books. They were even too rare to be in the treasure room the treasure the treasure room. Um, to see those,

I think you have to be a member and arrange to see it, or maybe very occasionally they exhibit those books, but anyway they weren't there to be seen. So I had to resign myself to not seeing them. But that was okay. I still very much enjoyed the British Library. We then left, and we wandered up towards Trafalgar Square, um, from King Cross. And then what did we do? We went we got the train down to embankment, we got the tube to embankment, walked up Villiers Street. We always have to walk up Villiers Street whenever we go to London. We looked out for an Italian restaurant that my father, my dad, um, used to love, and we went in there several times as a family with my mum, and Alice remembers going in as well. Um, we couldn't quite work out where it was. We think it's been replaced by something now, but we we knew roughly where it was. But we walked up to um, sort of Trafalgar Square area. And we decided to stop for a coffee. Now, we did, we went into Waterstones, Allison bought a book, and we thought we'd stop and have a coffee. We thought we'd go into the Waterstones cafe, but decided actually to go into um, um, a little cafe right next door to Waterstones. Quite a fancy looking place, and it had some extremely tasty looking cakes and pastries. So we sat down. It was outside. We had a beautiful view of Trafalgar Square and Nelson's Column. It was lovely and warm. Someone came out, asked us what we wanted. I ordered uh, I think I ordered a coffee and this slice of cake that I look looked nice. And Alison ordered a scone with jam and cream, and a and a latte or something like that. Anyway, we sat there for a while. I mean, when the scone came out, there was actually, it looked like there was two. And Alison was a bit surprised 'cause she thought she'd ordered one. But anyway, we we we ate everything. We sat there for about 45 minutes, loved it, very nice. When we came to pay, somewhat overwhelmed to find that the cost was um, nearly it was something like 42 pounds. Could only be accounted for the fact that the location was extraordinary, just on the Strand, just leading in Trafalgar Square. Anyway, paid it. Had to. Just sort of took it on the chin as they say and just left. But we then went into the National Portrait Gallery. This was something Alison has wanted to do. She always likes seeing galleries. Possibly because her mother was an art student and had a talent for art. But also she just likes paintings. So we went in, and I, you know, just speaking personally, I was I was in just very surprised at quite how the extent to which I enjoyed the National Portrait Gallery. In particular, portraits of people from times gone by, or now both living and now sort of dead. Uh, but recognized from my lifetime. People like David Attenborough, obviously still alive, but you know, Princess Diana, um, lots of different actors and and actresses, and sports just famous people. And it was the way they'd been captured by the artists was really quite extraordinarily enjoyable to see. They also had a contemporary arts room of portraits, uh you know paintings from like 2020, you know, in the last two, three years, and um, the what the were just absolutely fantastically beautifully painted, and they just just looking at them just moved, just moving, and I really enjoyed it, and Alison did as well, felt the same way. And we just enjoyed it, just much, much more than I I'd expected. And again, free to enter. Um, we left. Now, as as my recollection goes now, we, what did we do next? I think we must have gone to eat somewhere at that point, but I honestly can't remember. Just trying to think for a moment. No, I can't remember where we ate at the moment. It might come back to me. Um, I think actually we just went and had a pizza or something like that. It was something quite basic, but somewhere nearby. Because our next stop was actually um, County Hall on the south side of the river to go and see a play called Witness for the Prosecution, an Agatha Christie play. And it's um, playing in London at the

moment and it's um, it is acted in the original debating chamber in County Hall, which was the um, home of the Greater London Council for many, many years. But it's now actually just a kind of a collection of all sorts of touristy things, so it's long since, well, for quite a long time now, not been the Greater London Council. But it was the the auditorium, the room where the play was presented was absolutely just striking. Um, a huge kind of or very ornate and serious-looking chamber with the seats in a circle where the two different, where the various counselors would debate and make, you know, make laws of the that affect the London area. It was very atmospheric. So we were sat there in our lovely sort of leather comfy chair. Um, and then the play started, and the play was, first of all, incredibly well acted. It was very, very atmospheric. It was very enjoyable. It was very immersive. You felt like you were just right in the middle of the action. And the actual plot was very engaging. It was classic Agatha Christie with really funny, interesting sort of, you know, like 1930s characters. It also was quite funny the way it had that kind of classic Agatha Christie sort of English middle-class or upper-middle-class kind of feel to it. Sort of often repeating how England had the greatest justice system in the world, and the way, you know, so much better than foreign countries. I don't know, it was just quite funny and really enjoyable as well. So we watched all of that. We then had to walk back to or get back to our hotel. This was about now 10:00 p.m. or something. So we walked back from um, County Hall is really near Waterloo railway station. So to get back, we had to walk over the Charing Cross footbridge, back to Embankment, got on the Embankment tube, back up to King Cross round on the Circle Line. And then the 15-minute walk back to our hotel. We were somewhat staggered to find we'd both we were both well over 20,000 steps. We always have a little bit of a joke, or at least I do, because Alison's legs being my legs are very short by the way, but Alison's one of the few people has shorter legs than me. So her step count is always like, you know, roughly 5 to 10% more than mine. So, you know, it was sort of 21,000 for me and about 23,000 for Alison. Which is a lot for us, we were really tired. And we turned in for bed, and that was the end of day one.